

“IT IS A PRESS, CERTAINLY, BUT A PRESS FROM WHICH SHALL FLOW IN INEXHAUSTIBLE STREAMS...THROUGH IT, GOD WILL SPREAD HIS WORD.”

Johannes Gutenberg, German inventor and printer (c. 1398–1468)

THE COMPETING AMBITIONS OF ITALY'S CITY-STATES, which had led to almost a century of war, was ended by the **Treaty of Lodi** in 1454. Milan, Venice, Florence, the Papal States, and Naples were the signatories. The treaty had been given additional impetus by the fall of Constantinople to the Ottomans a year earlier, when it became clear there was a need to present a united Christian front.

In 1454 or 1455, **Johannes Gutenberg** produced the first major book to be printed with a movable type **printing press**: the Gutenberg Bible. His method of printing meant that thousands of copies of books could be made relatively easily. The result was an explosion in the **spread of ideas and knowledge**, above all because works appeared in vernacular languages rather than exclusively in Latin and Greek.

In England, on May 22, 1455, armies belonging to the Duke of Somerset and Duke of York clashed in the Battle of St. Albans, the opening conflict of the **Wars of the Roses**. These were a series of civil wars between the **rival Plantagenet houses** of York and Lancaster, both of which had claims to the throne. **Henry VI**, a Lancastrian, was on the throne at the outbreak of the wars, but with the victory and accession of **Edward IV** in 1461, the conflict

Gutenberg Bible

Johannes Gutenberg produced only 180 copies of his Gutenberg Bible, but it marked the start of the age of the printed book.



King Henry VI

This anonymous portrait is of King Henry VI, reputedly a peaceful, pious man who suffered from prolonged bouts of severe mental illness.

seemed to have been won by the Yorkists. The wars continued until 1485, when Henry Tudor seized the throne (see 1483–85).

By the mid-15th century, **Prussia** (conquered by the Teutonic Knights two centuries earlier) had become resentful of its lowly status within the Baltic territories of the Teutonic Order. In 1454 the Prussian Estates revolted, and asked for Polish military support, beginning what was to become the **Thirteen Years' War** against the Teutonic Knights. The war ended in 1466 with the division of Prussia into two territories: one in the east still controlled by the Order, and so-called Royal Prussia, now a vassal state of the kings of Poland.



A Turkish miniature painting showing Mehmed II's forces attacking Belgrade, which they tried unsuccessfully to take from Hungary in 1456.

OTTOMAN EXPANSION CONTINUED IN THE BALKANS AND GREECE as Mehmed II pressed ahead in his determination to conquer the world for Islam. Mehmed attempted to take **Belgrade** in 1456 but was repulsed by Hungary. However, by 1459 the rest of **Serbia** was under Ottoman control. Simultaneously, the Ottomans conquered the Peloponnese in southern Greece, with Athens falling in 1456. Over the next two decades, Ottoman control of the Balkans was consolidated with the conquest of **Bosnia and Herzegovina**, and in the Aegean, remaining Christian-held islands—which were chiefly Venetian and Genoan—were clearly under threat.

In 1458, **Matthias Corvinus**, second son of Janos Hunyadi, the man who had led the successful defence of Belgrade against Mehmed II's Ottoman troops in 1456, was elected **king of Hungary**. His reign promised much: not only to draw the Hungarians into the wider European Renaissance, but also to increase the reach and prestige of his country.

Corvinus was permanently distracted by the need to defend Hungary against further Ottoman incursions, but he had **territorial ambitions** to the west. He was successful in substantially expanding Hungarian territory at the expense of **Bohemia**, against whose Hussite ruler, George of Podebrady (r. 1458–71), he obtained papal sanction in 1468 to lead a crusade. During the crusade, Corvinus gained control of **Moravia, Silesia, and Lusatia**. However, in the longer run his actions destabilized both Hungary and Bohemia, and brought him into conflict with the Holy Roman Emperor, Frederick III. His actions also sparked suspicion among Hungary's nobles, who feared that their own positions would be undermined.

Despite these initial territorial gains engineered by Corvinus, the net result was that most of Hungary fell victim to **Ottoman conquest** in 1526, and Bohemia and the remaining part of Hungary came under direct **Habsburg control**.

April 9, 1454 Treaty of Lodi signed in Lombardy, Italy

1454 Thirteen Years' War begins between Poland and Teutonic Order

1454/55 German printer Johannes Gutenberg publishes the Gutenberg Bible

February 18, 1455 Italian painter Fra Angelico (b. 1395) dies

April 8, 1455 Calixtus III becomes pope, succeeding Nicholas V

May 22, 1455 Rival claimants to English throne clash in Battle of St. Albans, starting the Wars of the Roses

December 1, 1455 Florentine goldsmith Lorenzo Ghiberti (b. 1378) dies

July 21–22, 1456 Hungary defeats Ottomans at Battle of Belgrade

August 20, 1456 Vlad III ('the Impaler') becomes king of Romania; his brutality gives rise to the legend of Dracula

January 20, 1458 Matthias Corvinus becomes king of Hungary at age of 14

1458 Ottomans take Athens